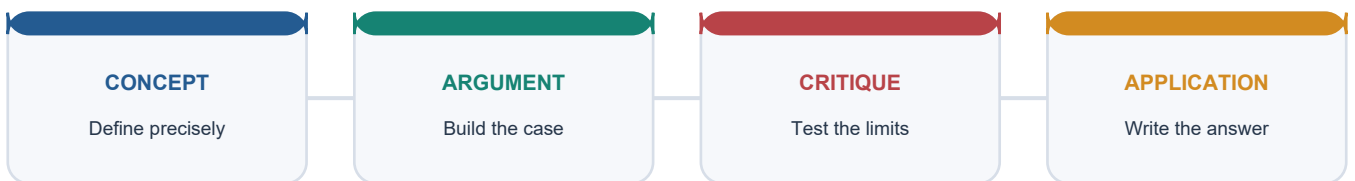


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Plato and Aristotle - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Plato and Aristotle - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the Greek term follows immediately in transliteration - *form* (*eidōs*), *participation* (*methexis*), *actuality* (*energeia*).

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed independently, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - Ideas; Substance; Form and Matter; Causation; Actuality and Potentiality - together with the Sun-Line-Cave argument, participation and its objections, Aristotle's critique, the *Categories/Metaphysics* question, hylomorphism, privation, teleology and the Unmoved Mover. The eight remedial drills attack the specific confusions that cost marks every year.

MCQ 1. What the theory of Forms is posited to solve

Consider the following statements about Plato's motivation for positing Forms (*eidē*).

1. Many sensible things are called by the same predicate, so a single intelligible character must be common to them.
2. Strict knowledge (*epistēmē*) requires an object that does not change, which sensible particulars cannot supply.
3. The theory is introduced principally to explain the efficient production of motion in the sensible world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it pairs the sound one-over-many premise with the one function Forms notoriously fail to discharge, since Aristotle's standing objection at *Metaphysics* I.9 is precisely that separated Forms cannot originate motion.
- **B:** Correct: the one-over-many argument (*hen epi pollōn*) and the argument from knowledge are the two load-bearing motivations, running from *Republic* V-VII and reported again at *Parmenides* 132a.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is sound but statement 3 imports an efficient-causal role that the middle dialogues never assign to Forms and that the *Timaeus* hands instead to the Demiurge.
- **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three treats an objection against the theory as though it were one of the theory's own purposes.

Examiner trap 1: Writing that Forms were introduced to explain change inverts the doctrine. Forms are introduced to explain stability and intelligibility *despite* change; explaining change is Aristotle's project, not Plato's.

MCQ 2. The exact sense of the "separation" of the Forms

When Plato is said to hold that Forms are separate from sensible particulars, the claim is best understood as meaning that

- A. Forms occupy a second physical location, lying spatially remote from the world our senses reach
- B. Forms are shared concepts assembled in the minds of those who use a common predicate correctly
- C. Forms exist independently of their sensible instances and are non-spatial and non-temporal
- D. Forms are the microscopic constituents out of which sensible particulars are assembled

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: "intelligible realm" is a structural expression, not a geography; a Form has no magnitude, shape or position, so it cannot be somewhere at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is conceptualism, which Plato rejects - the Form of Beauty would then depend on minds, whereas Plato needs it to be the standard against which minds are corrected.
- **C:** Correct: separation is ontological independence plus non-spatiality and non-temporality, which is exactly what the 2025 "timeless and spaceless" demand tests.
- **D:** Incorrect: making Forms physical parts revives the participation dilemma of *Parmenides* 131a-c, where a divided Form of Smallness would absurdly make its participants large.

Examiner trap 2: The word "realm" is safe only if you immediately deny that it names a place. Candidates who describe a second world with Forms sitting in it hand the examiner Aristotle's duplication objection ready-made.

MCQ 3. Matching each argument for the Forms to its structure

Match each argument with its distinctive move.

1. One-over-many - 2. Argument from knowledge - 3. Argument from opposites - 4. Recollection (*anamnēsis*)
- I. Sensible things are both F and not-F in different relations, whereas the F itself never is. II. We judge sensibles as falling short of a perfection we never met in sense, so the soul must have known it before. III. A common predicate applied to many requires one thing they all share. IV. Knowledge needs a stable object, and sensibles are in flux.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

- A. 1-III, 2-IV, 3-I, 4-II
- B. 1-IV, 2-III, 3-II, 4-I
- C. 1-III, 2-I, 3-IV, 4-II
- D. 1-II, 2-IV, 3-I, 4-III

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: one-over-many supplies the unity premise, the knowledge argument supplies the stability premise, the opposites argument at *Phaedo* 74a-75d supplies the non-relativity premise, and recollection at *Phaedo* 72e-77a and *Meno* 80d-86c supplies the access premise.
- **B:** Incorrect: it swaps the unity and stability premises and misassigns recollection to the relativity of sensibles.
- **C:** Incorrect: it makes the argument from knowledge turn on compresence of opposites, which is a distinct argument with a distinct textual home.
- **D:** Incorrect: it treats one-over-many as an argument about the pre-natal soul and reduces recollection to a claim about shared predicates.

Examiner trap 3: Recollection is one supporting route to the Forms, not Plato's whole epistemology. Answers that reduce Platonic knowledge to remembering lose the *Republic's* dialectical ascent entirely.

MCQ 4. "Ideas are timeless and spaceless"

The property that most directly explains why Forms can be objects of knowledge rather than of opinion is that they

- A. are more numerous and far more finely differentiated than the sensible things that imitate them
- B. admit no generation or alteration and occupy no position, being self-identically what they are
- C. are perceived by an inner sense which operates on much the same principles as ordinary sight
- D. change far more slowly than sensible particulars and therefore approximate stability more closely

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: number and differentiation are irrelevant to knowability; a large collection of changing items would still yield only opinion.
- **B:** Correct: timelessness and spacelessness make a Form incapable of being otherwise, and only what cannot be otherwise can be known in Plato's strict sense.
- **C:** Incorrect: Forms are grasped by reason (*nous*), not by any sense; an "inner sense" reading collapses the very distinction the 2025 question tests.
- **D:** Incorrect: degrees of slowness keep Forms inside time, whereas the claim is that they are outside it and therefore admit no comparative rate of change at all.

Examiner trap 4: "Eternal" is not the answer by itself. The examiner wants the inference - non-temporal and non-spatial, therefore incapable of being otherwise, therefore knowable - not a restatement of the adjective.

MCQ 5. What counts as substance for Plato

On Plato's view, true substance (*ousia*) is

- A. the concrete individual before us, since it alone is the ultimate subject of every predication
- B. the underlying matter, which persists unchanged through every change the individual undergoes
- C. the compound formed from an intelligible structure and a portion of the Receptacle
- D. the universal Form, with particulars possessing being only derivatively through participation

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Aristotle's *Categories* answer, and stating it as Plato's erases the inversion on which every comparison question turns.
- **B:** Incorrect: Plato has no doctrine of matter as substance; the nearest item, the Receptacle (*chōra*) of the *Timaeus*, is a difficult "third kind" and is expressly not straightforward Aristotelian matter.
- **C:** Incorrect: it fuses a *Timaeus* cosmological notion with a hylomorphic analysis that belongs to Aristotle, producing a doctrine neither philosopher holds.
- **D:** Correct: for Plato the universal is the truly real (*ontōs on*) and the particular is a derivative copy, which is the exact reverse of Aristotle's primary substance.

Examiner trap 5: Do not soften this into "both thought universals and particulars are real". The marks lie in naming the inversion sharply and then showing what it costs each thinker.

MCQ 6. The Divided Line

In the Divided Line of *Republic* VI 509d-511e, the ascending order of states of mind and their objects is

- A. *pistis* - images; *eikasia* - visible things; *noēsis* - mathematical objects; *dianoia* - Forms
- B. *eikasia* - visible things; *pistis* - images; *dianoia* - Forms; *noēsis* - mathematical objects
- C. *dianoia* - images; *noēsis* - visible things; *eikasia* - mathematical objects; *pistis* - Forms
- D. *eikasia* - images; *pistis* - visible things; *dianoia* - mathematical objects; *noēsis* - Forms

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the two lower states and inverts the two higher ones, destroying the correspondence between degree of clarity and degree of being.
- **B:** Incorrect: shadows and reflections belong to conjecture (*eikasia*), not to belief (*pistis*), and dialectic terminates in Forms rather than in mathematics.
- **C:** Incorrect: it assigns the two intellectual states to the visible section, which contradicts the primary cut of the line.
- **D:** Correct: conjecture takes images, belief takes visible originals, thought takes mathematical objects and intellection takes the Forms culminating in the Good.

Examiner trap 6: The line is one scale read twice - clarity in the knower matched to being in the known. Reproducing the four names without that correspondence answers only half the question.

MCQ 7. What separates *dianoia* from *noēsis*

The decisive difference between thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) in the Divided Line lies in

- A. the relative difficulty of the subject matter, geometry being distinctly easier than dialectic
- B. the direction of argument and the use of images, mathematics reasoning downward from hypotheses
- C. the number of premises each one employs, dialectic requiring more steps than geometrical demonstration
- D. the fact that only intellection is exercised by philosophers, since mathematics belongs to artisans

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: difficulty is a psychological accident; Plato's criterion is methodological, which is why the distinction survives even for an easy piece of dialectic.
- **B:** Correct: mathematics takes the odd and the even and the figures "as known" and gives no account of them, while dialectic treats hypotheses as steps up to an unhypothetical principle (*archē anhypothetos*) and descends through Forms alone.
- **C:** Incorrect: length of proof is not a criterion anywhere in the passage and would make the classification vary with the theorem chosen.
- **D:** Incorrect: the distinction concerns methods, not professions; the mathematician's method remains *dianoia* however philosophical the practitioner.

Examiner trap 7: This is the single most examinable point in the Line. An answer that names the four segments but cannot say *why* mathematics falls short has given a description where an analysis was demanded.

MCQ 8. What the Cave adds to the Line

Consider the following statements about the Allegory of the Cave, *Republic* VII 514a-517a.

1. The ascent is described as painful and compelled, and education is presented as turning an organ of vision the soul already possesses.
2. The philosopher must descend again into the cave, will see badly in the dark and may be met with ridicule or violence.
3. The allegory replaces the epistemological scheme of the Line with an independent political doctrine.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it drops the return (*katabasis*), which is the feature that converts the allegory into an argument about who should rule.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, so any combination containing it fails; Plato himself insists at 517a-b that the image "must be applied as a whole" to what preceded.
- **C:** Correct: compulsion and conversion (*periagōgē*), together with the descent and its transparent allusion to Socrates, are exactly what the Line does not contain.
- **D:** Incorrect: the Cave extends the Line into education and politics; it does not displace the epistemology it narrates.

Examiner trap 8: Retelling the story is the classic way to lose a ten-mark answer. Map the four stages onto the four segments, then add compulsion and the return, and the narrative becomes an argument.

MCQ 9. The Sun analogy

In the Sun analogy of *Republic* VI 507a-509c, the Form of the Good stands to the intelligible order as the sun stands to the visible order because the Good

- A. illuminates the Forms for the mind without contributing anything at all to what they are
- B. confers on the Forms both their knowability and their being, and lies itself beyond being
- C. is the efficient craftsman who fashions the Forms out of some pre-existing material stuff
- D. is simply the highest member of the class of Forms, differing from all the rest only in rank

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the analogy is deliberately double - as the sun gives visibility *and* generation, the Good gives knowability *and* being.
- **B:** Correct: this reproduces both limbs of the analogy and Plato's most audacious phrase, that the Good is "beyond being" (*epekeina tēs ousias*) at 509b.
- **C:** Incorrect: the craftsman is the Demiurge of the *Timaeus*, a different dialogue with a different explanatory role, and he does not create the Forms.
- **D:** Incorrect: mere seniority would not explain why the other Forms depend on it for being, nor would it license the "beyond being" formula.

Examiner trap 9: Equating the Form of the Good with the Demiurge, or with a personal creator, is a standing error. Keep the *Republic's* principle and the *Timaeus's* craftsman apart and say why.

MCQ 10. The participation dilemma

The dilemma about participation raised at *Parmenides* 131a-c presses the question whether

- A. the whole Form or only a part of it is present in each participant, neither answer being coherent
- B. Forms exist at all, given that nobody has ever perceived a single one of them by sight or touch
- C. participation is really a relation between two Forms rather than between a Form and a particular
- D. the Form of the Good participates in the lesser Forms in the way that particulars participate in Forms

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: both horns are stated in the text, and together they show that "sharing in" has not yet been given a coherent analysis.
- **B:** Incorrect: imperceptibility is a premise Plato accepts happily, not an objection; the dilemma is internal to the theory rather than empiricist.
- **C:** Incorrect: relations among the highest kinds belong to the *Sophist's* later refinement, not to the participation dilemma.
- **D:** Incorrect: the Good's relation to the other Forms is a question about grounding, and it is not the whole-or-part problem raised here.

Examiner trap 10: Plato states this objection against himself. Presenting the *Parmenides* difficulties as Aristotle's discoveries misreports the source and wastes the strongest evidence of Plato's philosophical honesty.

MCQ 11. The presuppositions of the Third Man

The regress known as the Third Man requires which pair of assumptions?

- A. That Forms are causally inert, and that sensible particulars are altogether unreal things
- B. That knowledge is recollection, and that the soul pre-exists the body it later occupies
- C. That the Form of F is itself F, and that the explaining Form differs from what it explains
- D. That every predicate has its own Form, and that the sensible world is in a ceaseless flux

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: causal inertness is a separate Aristotelian objection, and the regress does not need particulars to be unreal - only to resemble the Form.
- **B:** Incorrect: recollection is an argument for Forms, not a premise of the regress against them.
- **C:** Correct: self-predication plus non-identity generate the further Form at each stage, which is why denying self-predication is the standard Platonic escape route.
- **D:** Incorrect: the scope of Forms and the flux of sensibles are background theses; neither of them, alone or together, yields a regress.

Examiner trap 11: Name the two premises. An answer that merely says "an infinite regress of Forms follows" cannot show where the argument may be blocked, and blocking it is what a critical evaluation requires.

MCQ 12. Plato's wider causal resources

Which statement most accurately describes Plato's explanatory apparatus once the *Timaeus* is taken into account?

- A. Forms give formal explanation, the Good grounds being and intelligibility, and the Demiurge orders becoming after the Forms
- B. The Form of the Good and the Demiurge are two names for one creator who produces the Forms and the sensible world alike
- C. The Receptacle (*chōra*) is Plato's term for matter and functions exactly as Aristotle's *hylē* does in hylomorphic analysis
- D. Plato offers only one kind of cause, so Aristotle's charge that he cannot explain motion applies without any qualification

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it keeps three explanatory roles distinct and states the Demiurge's limits, which is the qualification the examiner rewards.
- **B:** Incorrect: identifying the Good with the Demiurge collapses a *Republic* principle into a *Timaeus* craftsman and is interpretively contested at best.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is a difficult third kind in which becoming appears, and it is not straightforwardly identical with Aristotelian matter.
- **D:** Incorrect: Plato has more than one explanatory resource; Aristotle's sharper charge is that *separated Forms themselves* do not explain motion or internal organisation.

Examiner trap 12: State Aristotle's objection in its accurate form. "Plato has no causes" is false and easily rebutted; "separated Forms cannot cause" is true and cannot be rebutted.

MCQ 13. Aristotle's critique of separated Forms

Which of the following states the "duplication" objection of *Metaphysics* I.9 correctly?

- A. Forms cannot be defined at all, because definition requires a genus and a differentia that Forms lack
- B. Forms are wholly unknowable, because knowledge proceeds only from the sense-perception of particulars
- C. Separated Forms double the entities requiring explanation, leaving two sets where there was one
- D. Forms are impossible, because nothing whatever can exist that is not located in space and in time

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a difficulty about definability that Aristotle raises elsewhere, and it is not the parsimony charge the question names.
- **B:** Incorrect: Aristotle holds that knowledge begins from sense and reaches universals, which is a positive epistemology rather than the duplication objection.
- **C:** Correct: Stace summarises the charge with Aristotle's own barb that the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature", so the explanatory debt is merely transferred.
- **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle nowhere argues that only spatio-temporal things exist - his own Unmoved Mover is immaterial.

Examiner trap 13: Keep Aristotle's five objections distinct: the Third Man regress, duplication, participation as metaphor, causal impotence and the absence of any account of generation. A merged blur earns one mark where five separated arguments earn several.

MCQ 14. Aristotle's repair of the theory of Forms

Aristotle's response to Plato is best described as

- A. rejecting form and universality altogether in favour of a strict materialism of atoms and void
- B. retaining Plato's separated Forms while adding efficient causation so as to make them effective
- C. accepting the Forms for mathematical objects while denying them for natural substances
- D. retaining intelligible form but making it immanent in the composite rather than separate

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Aristotle keeps form as the central explanatory principle, and atomism is the rival position he argues against.
- **B:** Incorrect: separation is precisely what he removes; adding an efficient cause to a separated Form would leave the regress and duplication charges untouched.
- **C:** Incorrect: he denies separate existence to mathematical objects too, and reports Plato's "intermediates" as a doctrine he does not share.
- **D:** Correct: the same word *eidos* is retained with a changed ontological status, which is the hinge of the 2024 comparison question.

Examiner trap 14: "Aristotle rejected the Forms" is a half-truth that reads as an error. He rejects their *separate existence* and their priority over individuals, and that precision is worth marks.

MCQ 15. Substance in the Categories

In the *Categories* (2a11 ff.), primary and secondary substance are related as follows.

- A. Primary substance is the species and secondary substance is the individual, since the species is more knowable
- B. Primary substance is the essence and secondary substance is the matter, since the essence explains the matter
- C. Primary substance is the concrete individual, and species and genus are secondary substances said of it
- D. Primary substance is the genus and secondary substance is the accident, since accidents inhere in genera

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses Aristotle's order and thereby reinstates the Platonic priority of the universal that the *Categories* is designed to overturn.
- **B:** Incorrect: essence and matter are the vocabulary of the *Metaphysics*, not the predication-based scheme of the *Categories*.
- **C:** Correct: "this man" and "this horse" (*tode ti*) are the ultimate subjects of predication, and everything else is said of them or is in them.
- **D:** Incorrect: accidents are not substances at all in this scheme, and the genus is the more remote of the two secondary substances.

Examiner trap 15: The *Categories* answers "which things are substances?" by a logical criterion of subjecthood. Importing the *Metaphysics* answer here, or vice versa, is the commonest structural error in substance questions.

MCQ 16. The four candidates for substance in *Metaphysics* Z.3

Aristotle reviews substratum, essence, universal and genus as candidates for substance. His adjudication is that

- A. essence is accepted, the universal and the genus are rejected, and bare matter is neither a "this" nor separable
- B. the substratum taken as matter is accepted, because stripping away predicates leaves the one thing that truly underlies
- C. the genus is accepted, because it is the widest term under which the thing in question may be classified
- D. the universal is accepted, since Aristotle agrees with Plato that only what is common to many can explain

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Z.3 rejects bare matter as a candidate, Z.4-6 and Z.17 install essence (*to ti ēn einai*), and Z.13 rules out the universal while the genus falls as predicated of many.
- **B:** Incorrect: it accepts exactly the candidate Z.3 eliminates, since what remains after every predicate is removed is neither determinate nor separable.
- **C:** Incorrect: a genus is predicated of many and therefore fails the same test that disqualifies the universal.
- **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle's agreement with Plato ends precisely here; Z.13 states that no universal is a substance.

Examiner trap 16: Reproduce the list with the verdicts attached. A candidate who names the four candidates without saying which are rejected and why has described a procedure instead of using it.

MCQ 17. The *Categories*/*Metaphysics* question

The safest way to handle the apparent conflict between the *Categories* and *Metaphysics* Z is to argue that

- A. the *Metaphysics* silently withdraws the *Categories*, so only the later of the two doctrines should be reported
- B. the two works are simply inconsistent and Aristotle himself never noticed the problem at all
- C. the two works answer different questions - which things are substances, and what the substance *of* a thing is
- D. "substance" is used equivocally in the two works, with no philosophical connection at all between the senses

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the developmental reading is available but rests on a disputed chronology, so it cannot be offered as the safe primary line.
- **B:** Incorrect: Z.17 shows Aristotle reformulating the question deliberately, which is evidence of design rather than oversight.
- **C:** Correct: the individual remains what exists in the primary way, while its form accounts for its being the individual it is - and Aristotle insists that being is said in many ways.
- **D:** Incorrect: bare equivocation severs the link, whereas Z.17's question "why is this matter a house?" shows the second sense explaining the first.

Examiner trap 17: Name at least two readings. Mentioning only the different-questions solution loses the credit available for the developmental, individual-form and species-form alternatives, each of which should be flagged as contested.

MCQ 18. The ten categories

The ten categories of the *Categories* are best described as

- A. fundamental modes of predication and of being, only substance being a subject primarily
- B. ten physical components which jointly compose every material object that we encounter in nature
- C. ten successive stages through which every natural substance passes as it develops to maturity
- D. ten distinct kinds of cause, of which the final cause is much the most important of all

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: substance, quantity, quality, relation, place, time, position, state, action and being affected classify ways of being said, and the nine non-substantial categories are in or said of substances.
- **B:** Incorrect: treating them as parts inside a thing is a category mistake in the literal sense; "yesterday" and "taller than Simmias" are not ingredients.
- **C:** Incorrect: developmental stages belong to the analysis of change through potentiality and actuality, not to the classification of predicates.
- **D:** Incorrect: the causes are four and belong to *Physics* II.3 and *Metaphysics* V, a different doctrine entirely.

Examiner trap 18: Substance *is*; accidents *belong to* substance. Fix that asymmetry first, and the difference between alteration and generation follows without further argument.

MCQ 19. Matter and form in hylomorphic analysis

Which statement about matter (*hylē*) and form (*morphē*) is correct?

- A. Matter and form are two independently existing objects that a craftsman joins mechanically together
- B. Matter is always the same featureless stuff, so bronze and wood differ only in the forms imposed on them
- C. Form is a separately existing paradigm that the matter of each substance imitates at a distance
- D. Matter is relative, since bronze is matter for the statue yet is itself formed from copper and tin

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: they are principles of analysis, not parts in a box; if they were separable objects the unity of the composite would be lost.
- **B:** Incorrect: it confuses proximate matter, which is always already determinate, with the limiting notion of prime matter.
- **C:** Incorrect: that is the Platonic paradigm relation, which Aristotle's immanent form is designed to replace.
- **D:** Correct: relativity of matter and correlativity of the pair are the two features that let one scheme cover artefacts, organisms, change and definition.

Examiner trap 19: The 2025 statement "everything in the empirical world is a compound of Matter and Form" must be evaluated, not merely endorsed. It holds of sensible substances; accidents taken apart, mathematical abstractions and the immaterial Unmoved Mover are not further compounds in the same sense.

MCQ 20. Prime matter

The doctrine of prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is best presented in an answer as

- A. a limiting posit of matter considered without determinate form and never existing independently
- B. an observable featureless stuff that chemists have since identified with the elementary particles
- C. a synonym for the Receptacle of Plato's *Timaeus*, which Aristotle adopted without any change
- D. the substantial form that is shared by all material things whatever their species may be

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: it is required to explain radical generation but is never actual on its own, and how far Aristotle commits to a single featureless prime matter is contested.
- **B:** Incorrect: presenting a limit concept as an observed stuff is exactly the error that invites the charge of unintelligibility.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is Plato's difficult third kind and is not straightforwardly Aristotelian matter.
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the definition, since prime matter is characterised by the absence of determinate form rather than by possessing a universal one.

Examiner trap 20: Concede the objection and then answer it. "Prime matter is unintelligible" is a real criticism; the reply is that it is a limit concept demanded by substantial generation, not a candidate for observation.

MCQ 21. The four causes

Which statement about the four causes (*aitiai*) is correct?

- A. They are four successive events, so the material cause acts first and the final cause acts last
- B. They are four competing hypotheses, of which the investigator must select the single true one
- C. They are four agents that act upon a thing from outside and may be observed quite separately
- D. They are four answers to "why?" about one thing, and in nature three of them typically coincide

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the four can be simultaneous, and Stace notes that in every case of production all four operate together rather than in sequence.
- **B:** Incorrect: they are complementary rather than rival; a complete explanation gives all four.
- **C:** Incorrect: the material and formal causes are internal principles, and only the efficient cause is typically an external agent.
- **D:** Correct: the form of the oak is what the acorn is for and what directs its development, which is why Aristotelian teleology is internal rather than designed.

Examiner trap 21: Use one worked example - the statue or the house - through all four causes. Four definitions attached to four different examples reads as a glossary, not as an explanation.

MCQ 22. Change, privation and the two kinds of change

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's analysis of change.

1. Coming-to-be is analysed through an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior privation (*sterēsis*) of that form.
2. In accidental change the substantial form persists while a quantity, quality, place or other accident alters.
3. In substantial generation the prior substantial form persists as the identity of the new substance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the unmusical man becoming musical illustrates subject, form and privation, and accidental change is precisely the case in which the substance survives.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, because in substantial generation an underlying material potential acquires a *new* substantial form.
- **C:** Incorrect: it retains the same false claim about substantial change while dropping the correct account of accidental change.
- **D:** Incorrect: accepting 3 would make generation indistinguishable from alteration and would leave destruction unexplained.

Examiner trap 22: Reserve "the form persists" for accidental change. Saying it of substantial generation contradicts the doctrine and undermines any answer on developmental change in substance.

MCQ 23. Potentiality and actuality

Aristotle's definition of change at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) is best rendered as

- A. the actuality of the potential as potential, a passage from potential to actual being
- B. the replacement of one actual thing by another actual thing that is numerically different
- C. the movement of matter through space under the action of some external moving agency
- D. the appearance of a wholly new being out of absolute non-being at each successive moment

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the qualification "as potential" is what makes the formula describe the process rather than its completed result.
- **B:** Incorrect: replacement without an underlying potential reintroduces the Parmenidean problem that the doctrine is designed to solve.
- **C:** Incorrect: locomotion is only one species of change; Aristotle's *kinēsis* also covers alteration, growth and generation.
- **D:** Incorrect: creation from absolute non-being is exactly what Aristotle denies, since nothing comes from nothing.

Examiner trap 23: Do not drop the phrase "as potential". Without it the definition collapses into the description of a finished actuality and answers nothing about becoming.

MCQ 24. The priority of actuality

Aristotle argues that actuality (*energeia*) is prior to potentiality (*dynamis*) in which respects?

- A. In spatial position, in numerical count and in bare perceptibility to the senses
- B. In causal power, in metaphysical dignity and in popularity among his later successors
- C. In explanatory efficiency, in theoretical economy and in the overall simplicity of statement
- D. In definition, in time at the species level, and in substance as the end of the process

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: none of these is a mode of priority Aristotle recognises, and Forms and actualities are not spatially ordered at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: dignity and reception are rhetorical rather than metaphysical grounds and prove nothing about the relation of the two notions.
- **C:** Incorrect: methodological virtues are not the argument; the argument concerns definition, generation and end.
- **D:** Correct: to define "potentially F" you must already grasp actual F; only an actual oak produces acorns; and the end is what the process is for.

Examiner trap 24: Priority is explanatory, definitional and teleological - not temporal in every sense. An individual potential state can precede its own actualisation in time, and conceding that openly strengthens the answer.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - what Plato says about the physical world

A candidate writes that Plato "denies the reality of the physical world". The correct correction is that Plato

- A. holds the sensible world to be a systematic illusion projected by ignorance, much as Advaita treats *māyā*
- B. grants sensible particulars a real but derivative being as copies of Forms, hence objects of opinion
- C. treats the physical world as fully real and equal in status to the Forms, differing only in accessibility
- D. leaves the ontological status of the physical world entirely undetermined throughout the dialogues

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: illusionism is precisely the position Plato does not hold; a copy is a defective instance of what it copies, not a non-entity.
- **B:** Correct: derivative reality is the accurate formula, and it explains why sensibles yield belief (*pistis*) rather than nothing at all.
- **C:** Incorrect: equal status would destroy the argument that different faculties must have different objects, argued at *Republic* V 476e-480a.
- **D:** Incorrect: the two-level scheme assigns the sensible world a definite subordinate status, so indeterminacy is not the reading.

Examiner trap 25: Comparisons with Advaita's *māyā* are legitimate only when the difference is stated. Plato degrades the sensible world's rank; he does not deny that it is there.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - what Aristotle denies about universals

Which correction of the claim that "Aristotle denies universals" is accurate?

- A. He denies universals in logic but retains them in physics, where species-terms are indispensable
- B. He accepts universals as separately existing entities but denies that they can ever be known
- C. He accepts universals only as names, holding that nothing in reality corresponds to a general term
- D. He retains species and genus as secondary substances, denying only their separate existence

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the same account of universals runs through both, since predication in the *Categories* is not restricted by subject matter.
- **B:** Incorrect: separate existence is what he rejects, and universals are for him precisely what science knows.
- **C:** Incorrect: nominalism is a later medieval position; Aristotle grounds the universal in the immanent form of the individual.
- **D:** Correct: "man" and "animal" remain secondary substances, less real than *this* man, which is the exact and defensible formulation.

Examiner trap 26: Precision here converts a wrong answer into a strong one. Write "he rejects *separated* Forms", never "he rejects forms", and the entire comparison keeps its balance.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - what potentiality is not

The claim that "potentiality is indefinable", tested in 2021, is best explained by saying that potentiality

- A. is a statistical likelihood that a given outcome will occur, measurable in principle by frequency
- B. cannot be defined independently of actuality, since "potentially a table" presupposes an actual table
- C. is undefinable because Aristotle nowhere discusses it, leaving only later commentators to supply an account
- D. is a hidden quality inside matter that can be detected once the matter is sufficiently divided

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: *dynamis* is an ontological capacity of a determinate material, not a probability; wood is potentially a table whatever the frequency of carpentry.
- **B:** Correct: this is why actuality is conceptually prior even where the potential state precedes in the individual's own time.
- **C:** Incorrect: *Metaphysics* IX (Θ) is devoted to the pair, so silence is not the ground of indefinability.
- **D:** Incorrect: division reveals more matter, never a capacity; the capacity is intelligible only through the actuality it is a capacity for.

Examiner trap 27: The wooden-table example must run through all three stages - block of wood, the carpenter's working, the finished table - and must be labelled *dynamis*, *kinēsis* and *energeia/entelecheia*. A bare example without the vocabulary is half an answer.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - how the Unmoved Mover moves

The Unmoved Mover of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 moves the cosmos

- A. by efficient causation, imparting motion to the outermost sphere by direct physical contact with it
- B. by creating the world out of nothing at a first moment of time, before which nothing existed
- C. as a final cause, being the object of desire and thought - it "moves as the beloved moves the lover"
- D. by continuously sustaining matter in existence, acting as a conserving cause at every instant

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: pushing would make the mover itself moved and would reintroduce the potentiality that pure actuality excludes.
- **B:** Incorrect: creation from nothing at a first moment is a later theological doctrine; Aristotle's cosmos and its motion are eternal.
- **C:** Correct: attraction rather than propulsion is the whole point, and it is why the mover can be immaterial, changeless and thought thinking itself (*noēsis noēseōs*).
- **D:** Incorrect: conservation belongs to the scholastic development of the doctrine, not to Aristotle's own argument.

Examiner trap 28: Do not assimilate the Unmoved Mover to a personal creator. It completes the actuality-potentiality system as the ultimate explanatory terminus, and saying so keeps the answer inside the printed clause.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - the four causes as explanation, not narrative

A script states: "First the material cause supplies wood, then the efficient cause acts, then the formal cause appears, and finally the final cause is reached." The error is that

- A. the order given is right but the labels have been interchanged between the formal and final causes
- B. the four are aspects of one explanation and may be simultaneous rather than successive events
- C. there are five causes on Aristotle's mature view, and the list omits the instrumental cause
- D. only the efficient cause is a genuine cause, the other three being metaphors for it

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: relabelling leaves the deeper mistake untouched, which is the conversion of an explanatory scheme into a chronology.
- **B:** Correct: Aristotelian causation includes what we would call reasons as well as causes, and all four operate together in any case of production.
- **C:** Incorrect: the causes are four, and the instrumental factor is an aspect of efficient causation rather than a fifth kind.
- **D:** Incorrect: reducing the four to the efficient cause is the modern narrowing that Aristotle's scheme is designed to resist.

Examiner trap 29: The word "cause" is wider in Aristotle than in modern usage. Say so in one clause, and the four-cause doctrine stops looking like bad physics and starts looking like a theory of explanation.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - formal cause and Platonic Form

The relation between Aristotle's formal cause and Plato's Form is that

- A. they are the same entity described in two vocabularies, so the dispute between the two philosophers is merely verbal
- B. both are called *eidos*, but Aristotle's is immanent in *this* composite and Plato's is separate
- C. the formal cause is a mental concept, whereas the Platonic Form is an object outside the mind
- D. Aristotle abandoned the word *eidos* precisely in order to mark his break with his teacher

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: separation versus immanence changes what the entity can do, so the dispute is substantive rather than terminological.
- **B:** Correct: the shared word with a changed ontological status is exactly what makes this the favourite trap in comparison questions.
- **C:** Incorrect: making the formal cause mental is conceptualism, which neither philosopher accepts.
- **D:** Incorrect: he retains the word deliberately, which is why the distinction must be drawn by ontological status rather than by vocabulary.

Examiner trap 30: In the 2024 comparison, run one axis - separated paradigm versus immanent essence - and then derive the consequences for causation, generation, universals and substance. Two parallel summaries score poorly.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - the standing of the "mathematicals"

The doctrine that Plato posited mathematical objects as intermediates (*ta metaxu*) between Forms and sensibles should be reported as

- A. a doctrine stated explicitly in the *Republic* alongside the account of the Divided Line
- B. a modern scholarly conjecture with no ancient textual or doxographical support whatever
- C. Aristotle's testimony at *Metaphysics* I.6 (987b14), not a doctrine stated in the dialogues
- D. a Neoplatonic addition of the third century which later editors inserted into the Platonic text

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Line assigns mathematical objects to thought (*dianoia*) but never states a separate order of intermediate entities.
- **B:** Incorrect: the report is ancient and is Aristotle's own, so calling it a modern conjecture misstates the evidence.
- **C:** Correct: the safe formula is "on Aristotle's testimony", which shows source discipline and protects the claim from challenge.
- **D:** Incorrect: there is no textual-interpolation story here, and inventing one would be a fabricated evidential claim.

Examiner trap 31: Attribute reports to their reporters. The name "Third Man" likewise comes from Aristotle at *Metaphysics* 990b17 and 1039a2; the argument itself is Plato's at *Parmenides* 132a-b.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - citation and verdict discipline

Which answer-writing practice is defensible in this topic?

- A. Quoting long passages of Jowett's translation from memory to establish the exact wording of a Platonic argument
- B. Citing "Plato, *Republic*, Chapter 7, page 214" so that the examiner can locate the passage in a particular printed edition
- C. Ending a comparison with a balanced description of both thinkers and no ruling, since UPSC penalises taking sides
- D. Citing Plato by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, and closing with a graded verdict

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: translations differ markedly, so a remembered wording is the least reliable evidence available; prefer the reference to the quotation.
- **B:** Incorrect: chapter and page numbers vary between editions, whereas Stephanus and Bekker references are edition-invariant.
- **C:** Incorrect: a directive such as "critically discuss" or "evaluate" obliges a ruling; balanced description without a verdict answers the topic instead of the question.
- **D:** Correct: edition-invariant citation plus a reasoned verdict is the combination that signals textual control and analytical nerve together.

Examiner trap 32: A verdict must follow from the body and must be graded rather than absolute - for example, that Aristotle's immanent form solves Plato's causal problem while inheriting his problem about universals.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2019, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts were read directly from the official question papers held in books\philosophy_optional\, and the 2018 and 2020 parts follow the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Doctrinal claims are attributed to their dialogue or treatise, and interpretive disputes - the *Categories/Metaphysics* question, individual versus species form, the status of prime matter, the significance of the equal middle segments of the Divided Line - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks - about 150 to 200 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 300 words**, and **20 marks - about 340 to 400 words**. Each solution prints the timed answer first; where a paragraph is marked *Depth refinement*, it is a teaching addendum that sits **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: twelve directly owned Plato-Aristotle PYQs from 2018 to 2025 - every part the ledger routes to this syllabus item, in every year of the corpus - and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Plato is cited by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, with *Metaphysics* books given once in both conventions - "Book VII (Z)". References are preferred to remembered quotations, because translations differ markedly.

2018 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is the relation between the Idea and the World as discussed by Plato logically consistent? Discuss Aristotle's views regarding this and also give arguments in favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three-limbed: a verdict on logical consistency , an exposition of Aristotle's objections, and the candidate's own supporting arguments
Limb 1	State the relation exactly - participation (<i>methexis</i>) and imitation (<i>mimēsis</i>) - then test it for coherence
Limb 2	Aristotle's objections as arguments , not as a list of complaints
Limb 3	A signed verdict with reasons, not a neutral summary
Scope boundary	Stay on the Idea-world relation; do not drift into the Cave, ethics or politics
Ideal thesis	The relation is not strictly inconsistent, but it is explanatorily incomplete , and the incompleteness is what Aristotle's objections convert into a refutation of <i>separation</i>
Non-negotiables	<i>Parmenides</i> 131a-c and 132a-b; self-predication and non-identity; duplication; causal impotence; the immanent-form repair

Independent model answer

The relation, stated. Sensible particulars are what they are by *participation* (*methexis*) in, or *imitation* (*mimēsis*) of, separately existing Forms (*eidē*): the rose is beautiful through Beauty itself, the chair is a chair through Chairness. The relation therefore carries the whole explanatory weight of the theory.

Is it consistent? Plato himself supplies the pressure. At *Parmenides* 131a-c the participant must receive either the whole Form - which then is separated from itself - or a part, whereupon a divided Form of Smallness would make its participant large. At 132a-b, if the Form of Man is itself a man and must differ from what it explains, a further Form is required, and the regress Aristotle names the Third Man begins.

Aristotle's views. In *Metaphysics* I.9 he presses four charges: separated Forms merely **duplicate** the explananda; "participation" is a **metaphor** rather than an analysis; a non-spatial, changeless Form cannot be an **efficient cause** of change; and the theory gives **no account of generation**. Stace records his sharpest barb - the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature".

My arguments and verdict. ANALYSIS: Strictly, no contradiction has been demonstrated: the regress needs self-predication, which Plato may deny, and the whole-or-part dilemma assumes Forms behave like extended bodies, which a spaceless entity does not. The relation is therefore not proven inconsistent - but it is **explanatorily empty**, since a relation that cannot be specified cannot do explanatory work, and Plato never specifies it. Aristotle's repair, keeping intelligible form and making it the immanent essence of the composite, answers the objection without abandoning the insight that intelligibility requires form.

Depth refinement. Note the asymmetry the examiner rewards: Aristotle defeats *separation*, not *form*. That is why the dispute does not end here but reappears as the medieval problem of universals.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2018 Q4(b): all three limbs must be visible. A script that expounds the theory of Forms and then reports Aristotle's objections has answered two of three and forfeited the verdict.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: relation in three lines; the two *Parmenides* difficulties in four; four Aristotelian charges in four; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** state the relation -> test it internally -> report Aristotle's objections as arguments -> deliver a reasoned verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *methexis*, *mimēsis*, paradigm and copy, self-predication, non-identity.
- **Evidence:** *Parmenides* 131a-c and 132a-b; *Metaphysics* I.9; Stace's "eternalized things of nature".
- **Distinction:** inconsistency versus explanatory emptiness - the sharper and more defensible charge.
- **Criticism:** name what each objection needs as a premise, so the reader can see where Plato might resist.

2019 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: What does Plato want to prove by his 'Allegory of Cave'?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What does he want to prove" - state the conclusions , do not retell the story
Core issue	The Cave is the Divided Line narrated as education and conversion, and it ends in a political claim
Scope boundary	Ten marks: four stages, two additional features, one verdict - no extended cosmology
Ideal thesis	Three theses: degrees of reality track degrees of cognition; education is conversion, not transmission; and the one who has seen the Good must return to rule
Non-negotiables	<i>Republic</i> VII 514a-517a; the mapping onto <i>eikasia</i> , <i>pistis</i> , <i>dianoia</i> , <i>noēsis</i> ; <i>periagōgē</i> ; the return (<i>katabasis</i>) and the Socrates allusion

Independent model answer

Plato's allegory at *Republic* VII 514a-517a proves three theses, and he insists at 517a-b that it "must be applied as a whole" to the Sun and the Line.

First, an ontological-epistemic thesis. The four stages of the ascent - shadows, the fire and carried artefacts, reflections in water, and finally the things themselves and the sun - map onto the four segments of the Divided Line: conjecture (*eikasia*), belief (*pistis*), thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*). Degrees of clarity in the knower track degrees of being in the known, and the sun stands for the Good, which gives the Forms knowability and being.

Second, a thesis about education. The release is violent and compelled; the eyes ache; the prisoner would rather return. Education (*paideia*) is not the insertion of knowledge into an empty soul but the **turning around** (*periagōgē*) of an organ of vision the soul already has.

Third, a political thesis. The philosopher must **descend** again, will see badly in the dark, and may be ridiculed or killed - an allusion to Socrates. ANALYSIS: This step, from having seen the Good to being entitled to rule, is the weakest link, and is where Popper attacks in *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945).

Depth refinement. The epistemology can be accepted without the politics; Plato thought it could not, and saying so converts a retelling into an evaluation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2019 Q1(a): the verb is "prove". Narration earns nothing; the conclusions and their support earn everything.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: one line of context, three named theses with their evidence, one evaluative clause on the political inference.

- **Structure:** context -> thesis 1 with the Line mapping -> thesis 2 on conversion -> thesis 3 on the return -> one critical clause.
- **Doctrine:** *eikasia*, *pistis*, *dianoia*, *noēsis*, *periagōgē*, *katabasis*, Form of the Good.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* VII 514a-517a and the instruction at 517a-b to apply the image as a whole.
- **Value addition:** naming Popper shows that the political inference has been noticed as an inference.

2019 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: What are the reasons for developmental changes in substance according to Aristotle? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Reasons" is Aristotle's own word for <i>aitiai</i> - supply the four causes , not a narrative of growth
Core issue	Why a substance develops as it does, and why the account is complete only when all four causes are given
Scope boundary	Developmental change in substance - cover both accidental alteration and substantial generation, and say which is which
Ideal thesis	Development is the actualisation of a determinate matter's potential under the direction of an immanent final cause, analysable as subject, form and privation
Non-negotiables	Material, formal, efficient and final cause; <i>Physics</i> II.3; privation (<i>sterēsis</i>); coincidence of formal, efficient and final in natural things; accidental versus substantial change

Independent model answer

The framework. For Aristotle to know a thing is to know its causes (*aitiai*), and "cause" covers reasons as well as agents. *Physics* II.3 gives four: the **material** cause (that out of which), the **formal** cause (the what-it-is-to-be), the **efficient** cause (the source of change) and the **final** cause (that for the sake of which). Stace stresses that these are not alternatives - in every case of production all four operate together.

Applied to development. An acorn becomes an oak because (i) it has **matter** with the determinate potential to receive that form; (ii) an **efficient** process - parent, nutrition, environment - initiates and sustains the change; (iii) the **formal** cause specifies what it becomes, the oak-structure; and (iv) the **final** cause states what the process is for, the mature oak. In natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes **coincide**: the form of oak is both the organising principle and the end.

The structure of the change itself. Every coming-to-be requires an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior **privation** (*sterēsis*) of that form: the unmusical man persists, acquires musicality and loses the privation. In **accidental** change the substantial form persists while a quality, quantity or place alters; in **substantial** generation an underlying material potential acquires a *new* substantial form and a new substance exists.

ANALYSIS: Verdict. The account is powerful because it unifies structure, modality and explanation: matter-form-privation gives the structure, potentiality-actuality the transition, the four causes the reason. Its cost is a commitment to internal teleology, which modern physics abandoned and functional biology quietly retained.

Depth refinement. "Nature does nothing in vain" is a recurring Aristotelian maxim, not a claim that nature plans. Teleology here is the directedness of a process towards a mature form, not conscious design.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2019 Q2(b): the examiner is testing whether "reasons" is recognised as *aitiai*. A developmental narrative without the fourfold analysis misses the question.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: framework in three lines; one worked example run through all four causes; privation and the two kinds of change in four lines; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** define cause -> the four causes -> one example carried through all four -> privation and the two kinds of change -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *aitia*, *sterēsis*, substantial versus accidental change, coincidence of three causes in nature.
- **Evidence:** *Physics* II.3; the acorn-oak and unmusical-man cases; Stace on simultaneity.
- **Distinction:** structure, modality and explanation are three different jobs done by three different pairs of concepts.
- **Criticism:** name the teleological commitment explicitly, then defend it as directedness rather than design.

2020 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How does Aristotle argue for the priority of Form over Matter and Actuality over Potentiality? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss" - reconstruct the arguments and press an objection
Core issue	Two parallel priorities, each defended in more than one sense of "prior"
Scope boundary	Priority, not a general exposition of hylomorphism
Ideal thesis	The priority is definitional, explanatory and teleological - never simple temporal precedence in the individual
Non-negotiables	Form as what-it-is-to-be; the three senses of the priority of actuality; <i>Metaphysics</i> IX (Θ); the temporal qualification

Independent model answer

Form over matter. Matter (*hylē*) is the "out of which", intelligible only as potential for some determinate form; form (*morphē*) is the what-it-is-to-be (*to ti ēn einai*) that makes the composite what it is. Wood does not tell us what a table is; the functional structure does. Form is therefore prior in **definition** and **knowability**, and at *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a **cause** - not "what is this?" but "why is this matter a house?", answered by the form.

Actuality over potentiality. Aristotle gives three senses. In **definition**, "potentially F" is unintelligible unless actual F is grasped - the point behind the 2021 statement that potentiality is indefinable. In **time at species level**, only an actual oak produces the acorn. In **substance**, the end is what the process is for, so the fully actual is the explanatory terminus, which at *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 is the Unmoved Mover.

ANALYSIS: Critical assessment. The definitional argument is strong but near-stipulative: if potentiality is *defined* by its actuality, posteriority follows analytically. The temporal argument holds only at species level; in the individual the potential state precedes. The teleological argument is only as secure as internal teleology. The priority is explanatory rather than absolute.

Depth refinement. Notice that the two priorities are the same claim twice: form is actuality considered structurally, actuality is form considered modally.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2020 Q1(a): two priorities, each with named senses, plus a real objection. Asserting "form is superior to matter" without senses is description.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: four lines on form, five on the three senses of actuality's priority, three of criticism.

- **Structure:** form over matter -> actuality over potentiality in three senses -> criticism -> one-line verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *to ti ēn einai*, *dynamis*, *energeia*, priority in definition, time and substance.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17, IX (Θ), XII (Λ).7; the wood-and-table and acorn-and-oak cases.
- **Distinction:** species-level temporal priority versus individual-level temporal posteriority - concede it and the answer looks controlled.
- **Value addition:** the closing identification of the two priorities as one doctrine is the sentence that lifts the script.

2021 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: "There is a red chair." How would Plato explain this statement with the use of his theory of forms? Examine.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine" - apply the theory to the given sentence and expose what the application reveals
Core issue	Multiple participation by one particular, and the epistemic status of the resulting judgement
Scope boundary	Work with the sentence given; do not substitute a general essay on Forms
Ideal thesis	The sentence is explained by participation in two Forms, and the explanation immediately exposes the unanalysed character of participation
Non-negotiables	<i>methexis</i> ; Chair and Redness as distinct Forms; belief (<i>pistis</i>) versus knowledge (<i>epistēmē</i>); the refusal to treat Forms as parts

Independent model answer

The analysis. "There is a red chair" refers to one sensible particular that is temporal, changeable and hence only derivatively real. Plato explains its determinate character by **participation** (*methexis*): it is a chair by participating in the Form of Chair, and red by participating in Redness. One particular may participate in several Forms at once without those Forms becoming physical constituents of it - a point that must be stated, since the contrary assumption revives the whole-or-part dilemma of *Parmenides* 131a-c.

The epistemic corollary. What sense delivers about this chair is belief (*pistis*), the third segment of the Divided Line. Knowledge (*epistēmē*) concerns Chair and Red themselves, which are timeless, spaceless and self-identical; the chair may fade or break, but Redness never becomes not-red.

ANALYSIS: Examination. The example is where the theory shows its strain. Saying the chair "participates in" Chairness **names** the relation without **analysing** it - Aristotle's charge at *Metaphysics* I.9 that participation is a metaphor. Two Forms have been invoked to explain one object, so the entities have doubled while the explanation has not deepened.

Verdict: Plato secures objectivity for "chair" and "red", but the sentence also displays the unpaid explanatory debt that motivates Aristotle's immanent form.

Depth refinement. Do not say the chair is unreal. It is a copy, and a copy is a defective instance of what it copies, not a non-entity.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2021 Q1(a): the marks lie in *using* the sentence. Multiple participation and the belief/knowledge split must both appear.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: analysis in five lines, epistemic corollary in three, examination in four.

- **Structure:** analyse the sentence -> give the epistemic status -> examine the cost -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *methexis*, derivative reality, *pistis* versus *epistēmē*.
- **Evidence:** *Parmenides* 131a-c for the part-whole warning; *Metaphysics* I.9 for the metaphor charge.
- **Trap avoided:** never let Redness become a red object elsewhere or a concept in the mind.

2021 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: "Potentiality is indefinable" according to Aristotle. Explain the relationship between potentiality and actuality with reference to the above philosophical position by taking the example of a "wooden table".

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... with reference to" - the quoted position and the prescribed example are both compulsory
Core issue	Why <i>dynamis</i> cannot be defined independently, and what that implies about priority
Scope boundary	Use the wooden table throughout; a second example dilutes the answer
Ideal thesis	Potentiality is grasped only through the actuality it is a potentiality for, so actuality is conceptually prior even where the potential state comes first in time
Non-negotiables	<i>dynamis</i> , <i>kinēsis</i> , <i>energeia</i> , <i>entelecheia</i> ; the three stages of the table; the anti-probability warning

Independent model answer

Why indefinable. Potentiality (*dynamis*) is a real capacity of a determinate material, not a probability. It cannot be defined without reference to what it is a potentiality **for**: to say the wood is "potentially a table" already presupposes that one knows what an actual table is. Aristotle therefore proceeds by analogy and example rather than by genus and differentia.

The wooden table, in three stages.

Stage	Description	Term
Block of wood in the workshop	possesses the capacity to become a table	<i>dynamis</i>
Carpenter cutting and joining	the actuality of the potential <i>as</i> potential	<i>kinēsis</i>
The finished table	the capacity fulfilled	<i>energeia</i> / <i>entelecheia</i>

The relationship. Actuality is prior in definition, since "potentially a table" presupposes "table"; prior in substance, since the finished table is what the process was for; and prior in time at species level, since actual tables and carpenters exist before this block acquires its form. ANALYSIS: In the individual's own history the potential state does precede its actualisation, and the answer should concede this.

Verdict: the pair is asymmetric but not vicious. Potentiality is illuminated by the actuality it is defined towards, which is why the doctrine explains becoming without predicting it.

Depth refinement. *Energeia* names the activity, *entelecheia* the completed state. Using both, and distinguishing them in one clause, signals control of *Metaphysics* IX (Θ).

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2021 Q1(b): the quoted statement must be **explained**, not merely repeated, and the wooden table must carry the whole exposition.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: indefinability in four lines, the three-stage table in a compact table, the priority and its qualification in four lines.

- **Structure:** why indefinable -> the three stages -> the relationship with its qualification -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *dynamis*, *kinēsis*, *energeia*, *entelecheia*; change as "the actuality of the potential as potential", *Physics* III.1 (201a10).
- **Distinction:** capacity versus probability - the single most common error in this question.
- **Value addition:** distinguishing *energeia* from *entelecheia* takes almost no words and is rarely done.

2022 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: How does Plato use the theory of forms to establish the relation between epistemology and metaphysics? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he use" - exhibit the mechanism by which the two disciplines are locked together
Core issue	The object determines the faculty, so degrees of being and degrees of knowing form one scale
Scope boundary	The link itself; the Cave is evidence, not the topic
Ideal thesis	Forms are posited because knowledge requires a stable object, so Plato's metaphysics is derived from an epistemological demand and his epistemology is graded by ontology
Non-negotiables	<i>Republic</i> V 476e-480a; the Divided Line at VI 509d-511e; <i>doxa</i> versus <i>epistēmē</i> ; the Sun analogy at 508b-509c

Independent model answer

The mechanism. Plato argues at *Republic* V 476e-480a that different faculties must have different objects. Knowledge (*epistēmē*) is infallible and set over what fully **is**; ignorance is set over what in no way is; opinion (*doxa*), fallible yet not empty, must be set over what lies between - sensible particulars that both are and are not F. The epistemological premise therefore **generates** the ontological conclusion: if knowledge is possible, there must be stable self-identical objects, and those are the Forms.

The scale. The Divided Line at VI 509d-511e makes the correspondence exact. Conjecture (*eikasia*), belief (*pistis*), thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) stand in clarity precisely as their objects - images, visible things, mathematical and Forms - stand in degree of being. The primary cut is *doxa* against *epistēmē*.

The apex. The Sun analogy at 508b-509c completes the identification: the Good gives the other Forms both **knowability** and **being**, so one principle grounds both orders.

ANALYSIS: Assessment. The unification is Plato's greatest achievement here and his greatest liability. Aristotle rejects the underlying assumption at *Metaphysics* I.9: being is said in many ways, not in **degrees**.

Depth refinement. The one-line formula worth memorising: for Plato, to know better is to be in contact with what is more.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2022 Q1(a): the marks lie in showing the **inference** from an epistemic requirement to an ontological posit, not in describing two doctrines side by side.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: mechanism in five lines, the Line correspondence in four, the Good in two, criticism in two.

- **Structure:** faculties and objects -> the graded scale -> the Good as joint ground -> the "degrees of being" objection.
- **Doctrine:** *epistēmē*, *doxa*, the four segments, the Good as ground of being and knowability.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* V 476e-480a; VI 508b-509c; VI 509d-511e.
- **Criticism:** Aristotle's denial that being admits degrees is the strongest available objection and takes one sentence.

2022 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is Aristotle's view of nature of identity in consonance with his metaphysical view of causes as processes? Discuss giving suitable examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A consonance question - a yes/no with reasons , plus compulsory examples
Limb 1	What supplies identity for Aristotle
Limb 2	What it means to treat causes as processes
Limb 3	Whether a stable identity and a processual causation can be held together
Ideal thesis	They are consonant because the identity-giving form is also the actuality towards which the process is ordered - a single principle in two roles
Non-negotiables	Substantial form as identity; four causes; accidental versus substantial change; at least two worked examples; the read-the-end-back-in objection

Independent model answer

Identity. For Aristotle a substance is what it is through its **substantial form** or essence (*to ti ēn einai*). At *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a **cause**: the question "why is this matter a house?" is answered by the form. Matter supplies determinate capacities, not a second identity.

Causes as processes. Causation for Aristotle is not bare succession. The four causes are four answers to "why?" about one ongoing thing, and in natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes coincide, so a cause is exhibited **in** a development rather than as an event preceding it.

Are they consonant? FACT: Yes, and for a structural reason: the **same form** does both jobs. It states what the thing is and it is the actuality towards which its determinate potential moves.

Example 1 - the oak. The acorn's matter has the potential for oak-form; parent and nutrition supply efficient causation; the oak-form is both what it becomes and what the growth is for. Throughout, the individual remains this developing organism. *Example 2 - the sculptor's bronze.* Casting is **accidental** change to the bronze, which persists; but the coming-to-be of a living thing is **substantial** generation, in which a new substantial form constitutes a new substance rather than modifying an old one.

ANALYSIS: **Objection and reply.** Defining a process by its completed form reads the end back into the beginning and understates contingency and failed development. Aristotle can reply that a potentiality is always a capacity of *this* material under *these* conditions, not a guarantee of success - the acorn reliably tends to oak, not to certainty.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict:** consonant, and more successfully than a static essence theory - but the consonance is purchased with internal teleology, which is the doctrine's real price.

Depth refinement. Keep "the form persists" for accidental change only. Saying it of substantial generation destroys the distinction the answer depends on.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2022 Q2(b): examples are demanded by the question, so an example-free answer is capped however good the theory.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: identity in three lines, processual causation in three, the consonance thesis in two, two examples in six, objection-reply-verdict in five.

- **Structure:** identity -> causes as processes -> the unifying claim -> two examples -> objection and reply -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *to ti ēn einai*, four causes, accidental versus substantial change, potentiality as conditioned capacity.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17; the acorn-oak and bronze-casting cases.
- **Criticism:** the retrospective-teleology objection is the one an examiner expects; supplying it and answering it is where the top band opens.

2023 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Present an exposition of Aristotle's distinction between actuality and potentiality. Does it provide a solution to the problem of being and becoming as presented in ancient Greek philosophy? Discuss with suitable examples.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two-limbed: exposition first, then an evaluated verdict , with examples
Limb 1	Define the pair, define change, state the priority
Limb 2	Frame the problem historically - Parmenides against Heraclitus - and judge whether the pair dissolves it
Ideal thesis	Yes: change is neither from being nor from sheer non-being but from potential being to actual being, which grants Parmenides his principle and Heraclitus his phenomenon
Non-negotiables	<i>dynamis, energeia, entelecheia</i> ; <i>Physics</i> III.1 (201a10); Parmenides and Heraclitus by name; two examples; the teleological limitation

Independent model answer

Exposition. Potentiality (*dynamis*) is the real capacity of a determinate material to become what it is not yet; actuality (*energeia*, and as completed state *entelecheia*) is that capacity fulfilled. Change (*kinēsis*) is defined at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) as **the actuality of the potential precisely as potential** - the qualification is essential, since without it the formula would describe the finished result rather than the process. Actuality is prior in definition, in time at species level and in substance, and the wholly actual admits no unrealised potentiality.

The problem. **Parmenides** argued that becoming is impossible: being cannot come from non-being, and being already is. **Heraclitus** held that all is flux, leaving no stable being to be known.

The solution. **FACT:** Aristotle refuses both horns. The acorn is not an oak **in actuality** but is an oak **in potentiality**; the wood is not a table in actuality but is one in potentiality. Becoming is therefore the passage from potential being to actual being - no leap from absolute non-being, so Parmenides' principle is respected; and real change, so Heraclitus' observation is preserved. Stability is secured not by denying flux but by locating the changeless in the **form** towards which change is ordered.

ANALYSIS: Limitations. The scheme is defined by reference to the actuality that terminates it, so it illuminates a process it cannot predict; and its explanatory power presupposes internal teleology, which post-Galilean physics discarded and functional biology retained under other names.

ANALYSIS: Verdict: yes - and it remains the most influential Western account of change, precisely because it is a **middle** position rather than a victory for either extreme.

Depth refinement. Note what "solution" means here. Aristotle does not refute Parmenides' logic; he distinguishes a third status - being-in-capacity - which the Eleatic dichotomy of being and non-being had no room for.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2023 Q2(b): two limbs, both scored. An exposition with no verdict, or a verdict with no exposition, halves the mark.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: exposition in six lines, the problem in two, the solution with two examples in five, limitations and verdict in four.

- **Structure:** define the pair and change -> state the historical problem -> apply the pair to it -> limitations -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *dynamis, energeia, entelecheia*, the "as potential" qualification, the three priorities.
- **Evidence:** *Physics* III.1 (201a10); acorn-oak and wood-table; Parmenides and Heraclitus named.
- **Analysis:** the decisive sentence is that Aristotle introduces a **third** ontological status, not a compromise between two.

2024 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Differentiate between Plato's and Aristotle's conceptions of form.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Differentiate" - run one axis consistently and derive consequences, not two parallel summaries
Core issue	Separated paradigm versus immanent essence, and what follows from that single difference
Scope boundary	Form itself; bring in causation, universals and substance only as consequences
Ideal thesis	Both call it <i>eidos</i> ; the whole dispute is whether it exists apart from its instances, and every further disagreement follows from that
Non-negotiables	Transcendence versus immanence; paradigm-copy versus what-it-is-to-be; consequences for causation, universals, knowledge and substance

Independent model answer

Both philosophers use the word **form** (*eidos*), and the entire difference lies in its ontological status.

Axis	Plato	Aristotle
Where form is	separate from instances; non-spatial, non-temporal	immanent in the composite as its essence
Relation to the particular	paradigm and copy: <i>methexis</i> , <i>mimēsis</i>	constituent principle: the <i>to ti ēn einai</i> of <i>this</i> thing
Explanatory role	F because it imitates the F itself	F because its matter is organised thus
Status of the universal	the truly real (<i>ontōs on</i>)	a secondary substance, less real than <i>this</i> horse
Causal function	paradigmatic and formal only	formal and final within the four causes
What is primary	the universal Form	the concrete individual (<i>tode ti</i>)

The consequences. By separating form Plato secures universality, objectivity and a stable object of knowledge - but pays with the participation problem, the Third Man regress and causal impotence. By immanentising form Aristotle explains generation, unity and change - but inherits the difficulty that form must be intelligible, hence universal, while *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13 denies that any universal is a substance.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict:** Aristotle keeps the form and drops the separation. He transforms Plato's insight rather than erasing it, which is why the dispute survives as the problem of universals.

Depth refinement. The single most useful memory image: Plato's form points **up**, away from the thing; Aristotle's form points **here**, into it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2024 Q1(a): one axis, run through consistently. Two biographies of two doctrines is the standard low-scoring shape.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: a compact matched table, four lines of consequences, one graded verdict.

- **Structure:** name the shared term -> the axis -> matched contrasts -> consequences -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *eidos*, *methexis*, *to ti ēn einai*, *tode ti*, secondary substance.
- **Distinction:** rejecting **separated** form is not rejecting form - say so explicitly.
- **Value addition:** ending with the problem of universals shows the contrast is live, not antiquarian.

2025 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: "Ideas are timeless and spaceless." Elucidate this statement with reference to Plato.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Elucidate" - derive the property from the doctrine; do not assert it
Core issue	Why non-temporality and non-spatiality follow from what a Form is, and what they buy
Scope boundary	The property and its consequences; not a general survey of Platonism
Ideal thesis	Because Forms are non-sensible and self-identical, they admit no generation, alteration or location - which is exactly what makes them knowable and what makes their causal role problematic
Non-negotiables	Timelessness as absence of generation and destruction; spacelessness as absence of magnitude and position; the <i>epistēmē</i> / <i>doxa</i> consequence; the separation cost

Independent model answer

Deriving the property. For Plato a Form (*eidos*, *idea*) is a non-material, self-identical universal - Beauty itself, not any beautiful thing. Two consequences follow directly. Being non-material, a Form has no magnitude, shape or position, so it is **spaceless**; the Form of Justice is not anywhere. Being self-identical, it cannot be generated, destroyed or altered, so it is **timeless**; it does not become more just or less just.

Why it matters. Only what cannot be otherwise can be strictly known. Timeless and spaceless Forms are therefore the proper objects of knowledge (*epistēmē*), while spatio-temporal particulars, which both are and are not F, yield only opinion (*doxa*). This is the load-bearing link between Plato's epistemology and his metaphysics.

Two cautions. ANALYSIS: "Intelligible realm" is a structural expression, not a second location - a spaceless entity cannot be *somewhere*. ANALYSIS: Nor are Forms concepts in minds, which would make the standard depend on the beings it corrects.

ANALYSIS: **Evaluation.** The property is the theory's strength and its wound. What lifts Forms above flux also removes them from the spatio-temporal order they are supposed to explain, which is precisely Aristotle's charge at *Metaphysics* I.9 that separated Forms cannot cause change or account for generation.

Depth refinement. The safest one-line formulation: Forms are not everlasting things inside time, but entities to which temporal predicates do not apply at all.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2025 Q1(a): "elucidate" demands a derivation. Listing adjectives - eternal, unchanging, perfect - is the failure mode.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: derivation in five lines, epistemic payoff in three, two cautions in two, evaluation in two.

- **Structure:** what a Form is -> spacelessness -> timelessness -> epistemic payoff -> cautions -> evaluation.
- **Doctrine:** *eidos*, self-identity, *epistēmē* versus *doxa*.
- **Distinction:** timeless versus everlasting - a distinction very few candidates draw.
- **Criticism:** the same property that grounds knowability grounds Aristotle's causal objection; saying so converts exposition into evaluation.

2025 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: "In the empirical world, everything is a compound of Matter and Form." Evaluate this statement with reference to Aristotle.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Evaluate" - test the scope of the quoted claim, do not simply endorse it
Core issue	Hylomorphism holds of sensible substances; the quantifier "everything" needs qualification
Scope boundary	The empirical world; the Unmoved Mover enters only as the boundary case
Ideal thesis	True of sensible substances and powerfully so, but "everything" must be restricted - accidents taken apart, mathematical abstractions and the immaterial mover are not further compounds in the same sense
Non-negotiables	<i>hylē, morphē, synolon</i> ; relativity of matter; prime matter as limiting posit; the exclusions

Independent model answer

The doctrine. Every sensible natural substance is a compound (*synolon*) of matter (*hylē*), the "out of which", and form (*morphē*), the organising essence: bronze and the shape of Hermes, wood and the design of a table, body and soul in a living organism, where the soul is the **form of the living body** (*De Anima* II.1). Matter is relative - bronze is matter for the statue but is itself copper and tin informed - and the two are correlative principles of one thing.

Why it is strong. It dissolves Plato's two-world problem without abandoning essence; it explains change, since matter can receive a different form; and it explains persistence, since substantial form survives accidental change.

ANALYSIS: Evaluating "everything". The claim holds of sensible substances. It does **not** extend to accidents considered apart, to mathematical abstractions, which Aristotle denies exist separately, or to the **Unmoved Mover** of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7, which is pure form without matter.

ANALYSIS: A residual difficulty. Prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is a limiting posit which never exists independently and whose textual standing is disputed; critics call it unintelligible, and the reply is that substantial generation requires it.

Verdict: true for sensible substances, but "everything" needs a stated boundary.

Depth refinement. The 2025 examiner has chosen a quantifier deliberately. Locating and defending the restriction is the whole difference between a competent script and a strong one.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus - 2025 Q1(b): "evaluate" plus "everything" is an invitation to find the limits. Uncritical endorsement scores as description.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: doctrine in four lines, strengths in two, the three exclusions in four, prime matter in two, verdict in one.

- **Structure:** doctrine with examples -> strengths -> the exclusions -> prime matter caveat -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *hylē, morphē, synolon*, relativity of matter, soul as form of the body.
- **Evidence:** *De Anima* II.1; *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 for the immaterial mover.
- **Value addition:** distinguishing artefacts from living substances shows why the doctrine was invented, not merely what it says.

Six original questions written in UPSC Paper I register - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. Each is solved to the same examiner-grade standard as the previous-year questions above, inside the declared word band, and each closes with a note on why the answer earns marks.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "What separates *dianoia* from *noēsis* in Plato's Divided Line is a difference of method, not of subject-matter." Comment.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct, and it identifies the single most examinable point in *Republic* VI 509d-511e.

The two marks of *dianoia*. Plato characterises thought (*dianoia*) by two features, neither of which concerns difficulty. First, it **uses visible things as images**: the geometer's drawn triangle stands for the triangle it is not. Second, it argues **downward from hypotheses** - the odd and the even, the figures, the three kinds of angle - which it "takes as known" and of which it "gives no account".

The contrast. Intellection (*noēsis*) proceeds by **dialectic**: it treats hypotheses as hypotheses, that is, as steps upward to an unhypothetical first principle (*archē anhypothetos*), and then descends through Forms alone, using **no images whatever**.

Why method and not subject-matter. Mathematical objects sit above visible things on the line, so the scale is not one of difficulty; a hard theorem remains *dianoia* and an elementary piece of dialectic remains *noēsis*. The criterion is the direction of argument and the presence or absence of images.

ANALYSIS: Qualification. The primary cut in the line is *doxa* against *epistēmē*; *dianoia* and *noēsis* are both knowledge, so the difference is one of purity within knowledge, not the difference between knowing and believing.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** thesis -> two defining marks -> contrast -> the reason the criterion is methodological -> qualification.
- **Evidence:** *Republic* VI 509d-511e; the geometer's diagram; the unhypothetical principle.
- **Distinction:** difficulty versus method - the discrimination the question is built on.
- **Discipline:** the closing qualification prevents the common overstatement that *dianoia* is a form of opinion.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Aristotle rejects the separation of the Forms, not form itself." Examine this claim.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim is accurate and is the precise formulation an answer on this topic needs.

What he rejects. At *Metaphysics* I.9 Aristotle argues that separated Forms **duplicate** what was to be explained, that "participation" is a **metaphor** rather than an analysis, that a changeless non-spatial entity cannot originate change, and that the theory gives **no account of generation**. The Third Man regress - stated by Plato at *Parmenides* 132a-b and named in Aristotle's reports - shows that self-predication plus non-identity multiplies Forms without end.

What he retains. Form remains the central explanatory principle: it is the **what-it-is-to-be** (*to ti ēn einai*) of the composite, and at *Metaphysics* VII (Z).17 substance is sought as a cause, so "why is this matter a house?" is answered by the form. Species and genus survive as **secondary substances**, and the soul is the form of the living body.

ANALYSIS: Examination. One qualification is needed. By immanentising form Aristotle inherits Plato's hardest problem in new dress: form must be intelligible and hence universal, yet *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13 denies that any universal is a substance.

Verdict: the rejection is of separation, not of form - and inheriting the universals problem is the price of the repair.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** thesis -> what is rejected, as arguments -> what is retained -> the inherited difficulty -> verdict.
- **Evidence:** *Metaphysics* I.9, VII (Z).13, VII (Z).17; *Parmenides* 132a-b; *De Anima* II.1.
- **Precision:** "rejects separated Forms" rather than "rejects forms" is itself a mark-earning formulation.
- **Balance:** naming the Z.13 difficulty prevents the answer from reading as Aristotelian propaganda.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "The *Categories* and *Metaphysics* VII (Z) give different answers because they ask different questions." Critically examine this resolution of Aristotle's account of substance.

Independent model answer

The apparent conflict. In the *Categories* (2a11 ff.) primary substance is the **concrete individual** - "this man", "this horse" (*tode ti*) - and species and genus are secondary substances said of it. In *Metaphysics* VII (Z) substance is the **form or essence** (*to ti ēn einai*), prior to the compound in being, definition and knowledge; matter is rejected as substance at Z.3; and Z.13 states bluntly that **no universal is a substance**, although form looks universal.

The proposed resolution. The *Categories* asks *which things are substances* and answers by a **logical-linguistic** criterion: the ultimate subject of predication. *Metaphysics Z* asks *what the substance of a thing is* and answers by a **causal-explanatory** criterion, reformulated at Z.17 as "why is this matter a house?". Two different questions may have two different answers, and Aristotle insists that being is said in many ways.

Critical examination. FACT: The resolution is the safest available and is textually well grounded. CAUTION: But it does not dissolve every difficulty. If form is the species-form, Z.13 generates a genuine aporia which Aristotle does not fully resolve - the reading associated with Owen. If form is individual in each substance - the Frede-Patzig line - the tension disappears but the universality science requires becomes harder to secure. Jaeger's developmental reading, that the *Categories* is early and Platonic-adjacent, depends on a chronology that is itself disputed.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict.** The different-questions reading should be **led with**, because it explains Z.3's rejection of bare matter and Z.17's reformulation as steps in one enquiry rather than reversals. It should then be **qualified**: the individual remains what exists primarily, but what accounts for its being that individual is its form, and whether that form is individual or specific is still contested. The change of question is real; it does not by itself settle the universals problem.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the conflict sharply -> state the resolution -> test it against the rival readings -> deliver a graded verdict.
- **Evidence:** *Categories* 2a11; *Metaphysics* VII (Z).3, Z.13, Z.17; three named scholarly readings.
- **Analysis:** showing that Z.3 and Z.17 are steps in one enquiry converts description into argument.
- **Discipline:** contested readings are labelled contested - the examiner is testing source honesty as much as content.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "Aristotle's final cause asserts directedness, not design." Discuss with suitable examples, and assess whether teleology survives the objection that it is unscientific.

Independent model answer

The doctrine. The final cause (*telos*) answers "for the sake of what?" and, in purposive and natural-developmental explanation, has a special priority because it states what the process is **for**. In natural substances the formal, efficient and final causes typically **coincide**: the form of oak is both the organising principle of the acorn's development and the end towards which it moves.

Directedness, not design. ANALYSIS: "Nature does nothing in vain" is a recurring Aristotelian maxim, appearing in *De Caelo*, the *Politics* and *De Partibus Animalium*; it asserts regularity of outcome, not deliberation. Nature is not an artisan with a plan. The example of the artefact - the carpenter making a table for dining - is a **teaching device** drawn from a case where intention really is present; Aristotle's serious cases are organisms, where the directing principle is internal.

Example 1 - the acorn. It reliably becomes an oak and never a cat. That reliability is what the final cause names.

Example 2 - the eye. Its structure is explained by what seeing requires, not by what a designer intended.

The objection. Post-Galilean physics dispensed with final causes and explained motion by efficient causation and law. If physics needs no *telos*, teleology looks like a superfluous metaphysical overlay.

Assessment. FACT: The objection is decisive **for physics** and much weaker elsewhere. Modern biology retained functional explanation under other names - adaptation, selective advantage, the function of an organ - which is directedness without design. CAUTION: The residual worry is real: unless directedness is cashed out independently, "for the sake of" risks describing the outcome and calling it an explanation.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict.** The final cause survives as an account of the directedness of natural processes towards a mature form; it does not survive as a rival to efficient-causal mechanism.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** doctrine -> the directedness/design distinction -> two examples -> the objection -> assessment -> verdict.
- **Evidence:** the maxim with its works named; acorn and eye; the coincidence of three causes in nature.

- **Balance:** conceding physics while defending biology is a graded verdict, not a hedge.
- **Precision:** flagging the artefact case as a teaching device pre-empts the standard charge of anthropomorphism.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Compare Plato's and Aristotle's metaphysics of form, and evaluate whether Aristotle's immanentism is an advance on Plato's transcendence.

Independent model answer

Frame. Both use the word *eidos*; the dispute is whether form exists apart from its instances. Everything else - causation, generation, knowledge, substance - follows from that difference.

Plato. Forms are eternal, non-material, self-identical universals, independent of sensible particulars and neither in space nor in time. They solve three problems at once: the unity of the many (*hen epi pollōn*), knowledge amid flux, and the objectivity of value. Particulars are what they are by **participation** (*methexis*) or **imitation** (*mimēsis*); the Form is paradigm, the particular imperfect copy. The Sun, Divided Line and Cave (*Republic* VI 507a - VII 517a) form one continuous argument in which degrees of cognitive clarity track degrees of being, with the Good giving the Forms knowability and being and itself said to lie "beyond being" (*epekeina tēs ousias*) at 509b. For Plato true substance (*ousia*) is the universal.

Aristotle. He inverts this. Primary substance is the concrete individual (*tode ti*); species and genus are secondary. Form is the immanent **what-it-is-to-be** (*to ti ēn einai*) of a composite (*synolon*); matter is relative and correlative to form. Change is analysed through subject, form and **privation** (*sterēsis*), explained by the **four causes**, and understood modally as passage from potentiality (*dynamis*) to actuality (*energeia*) - "the actuality of the potential as potential" (*Physics* III.1, 201a10). The system terminates in the Unmoved Mover, pure actuality moving as final cause (*Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7).

The critique. At *Metaphysics* I.9 Aristotle charges Plato with duplicating the explananda, leaving participation a metaphor, rendering Forms causally impotent and offering no account of generation; the Third Man regress at *Parmenides* 132a-b adds a formal difficulty.

Evaluation. FACT: Immanentism advances on three counts: it removes the regress by removing separation, makes form a genuine cause of *this* thing, and makes generation intelligible. CAUTION: It does not advance on a fourth: Plato's insight that intelligibility may require something beyond the particular is answered rather than refuted, and *Metaphysics* VII (Z).13's denial that any universal is a substance sets Aristotle a difficulty as deep as the Third Man. ANALYSIS: Nor is Plato as thin as Aristotle suggests: the *Timaeus* supplies a Demiurge ordering becoming after Forms and a Receptacle in which becoming appears, so the accurate charge is that **separated Forms themselves** explain neither motion nor organisation.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict.** Aristotle transforms Plato's insight rather than erasing it. The dispute is converted into the problem of universals and every later realism-nominalism debate.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** frame the single axis -> Plato -> Aristotle -> the critique -> a four-part evaluation -> verdict.
- **Evidence density:** *Republic* 507a-517a and 509b; *Parmenides* 132a-b; *Metaphysics* I.9, VII (Z).13, XII (Λ).7; *Physics* III.1; the *Timaeus* qualification.
- **Analysis:** conceding one count on which Aristotle does **not** advance is what makes the verdict graded rather than partisan.
- **Discipline:** the *Timaeus* correction prevents the answer from repeating Aristotle's polemical simplification of his teacher.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Plato's theory of Forms fails not from external attack but from the internal incompatibility of two demands it places on Forms." Critically evaluate.

Independent model answer

The two demands. The theory requires Forms to be **separate** - hence stable, self-identical, timeless, spaceless and therefore knowable - and simultaneously **explanatory** - hence involved in making particulars what they are. The claim under evaluation is that these two requirements pull against each other.

Evidence that the pressure is internal. FACT: Plato states the strongest objections himself. At *Parmenides* 131a-c the participant must receive either the whole Form, which is then separated from itself, or a part, whereupon a divided Form of Smallness would make its participant large. At 132a-b, if the Form of F is itself F and must differ from what it explains, a further Form follows and the regress begins. Neither argument is imported from a rival school; both arise from the theory's own commitments.

Aristotle's contribution. ANALYSIS: His objections at *Metaphysics* I.9 - duplication, participation as metaphor, causal impotence, no account of generation - largely **systematise** this internal pressure rather than introduce a new one. Stace's report of his barb, that the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature", is a diagnosis of the duplication that separation makes unavoidable.

The reply available to Plato. CAUTION: The regress requires self-predication and non-identity; deny self-predication and it weakens sharply, and the whole-or-part dilemma assumes Forms behave like extended bodies, which a spaceless entity does not. Vlastos reads the regress as a strict logical failure, Fine restricts what Plato must concede, and developmental readings see the later dialogues - the *Sophist* on the communion of kinds, the *Timaeus* on the Demiurge and Receptacle - as revision rather than abandonment. Whether the objections are resolved is genuinely contested.

Where the incompatibility bites hardest. ANALYSIS: Even granting every reply, the **explanatory** demand remains unmet: participation still lacks a non-metaphorical analysis. That is why the deepest objection is not the regress but the causal gap - a relation that cannot be specified cannot explain.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict.** The statement is largely correct but should be graded. The theory does not fail by demonstrated contradiction; it fails to discharge one of the two tasks it set itself, and the failure is internal, since separation was adopted precisely to secure the first task. This is why every later realism about universals keeps the explanatory demand and weakens the separation - which is exactly Aristotle's move, and exactly what leaves him with the universals problem in turn.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** name the two demands -> show the pressure is internal -> place Aristotle correctly -> give Plato's replies -> locate the real failure -> graded verdict.
- **Evidence density:** *Parmenides* 131a-c and 132a-b; *Metaphysics* I.9; *Sophist* and *Timaeus* as revision evidence; Vlastos and Fine as contested readings; Stace's report.
- **Analysis:** distinguishing "inconsistent" from "explanatorily incomplete" is the discrimination that decides the band.
- **Discipline:** treating the developmental question as open, rather than asserting that Plato abandoned the Forms, is the source-honest position.